Freud

The work of Sigmund Freud is one of the most important intellectual projects of the early 20th century, and its importance lies in several related factors, but perhaps the fundamental importance of Freud is that it brings together two incompatible or perhaps antagonistic trains of German late 19th century early 20th century thought. The two strains are positivism, the kind of rigid scientific materialism characteristic of late 19th century German science, which was championed by people like Mach and Avenarius, and German speculation, which has its origin in German idealism, but which is transformed in the late 19th century by figures like Brentano, who try and construct a psychology, a logos of the psyche, a discipline which discusses internal mental events rather than external objective events.

What Freud does, to his credit, is find a way of walking this tightrope of bringing together both elements of scientific positivistic objectivity and a concern to discuss facts of the human psyche which are inaccessible to direct physical or scientific examination. Freud has a foot in both camps. He is not a pure idealist, even though he deals with mental phenomena. He is not a pure materialist, even though he ultimately believes that mental phenomena can be reduced to physical facts. He wants to have his cake and eat it too. The degree to which he manages to connect these themes is one of the reasons why his work has been so influential, because commonsensically all of us have a sense that the world is a physical thing studied by science, but we also experience the world in such a way that it's hard to talk about our experiences entirely in terms of a reductive scientific language.

We feel love and hate, we feel guilt and pleasure, and it's hard to turn that into F = ma.

Freud manages to straddle both traditions. His conception of the self derives from Western philosophy, particularly Descartes, and marks a major change. For Descartes, the philosopher of systematic skepticism, the one thing he could not doubt was his own existence. Introspection, looking into the contents of one’s own mind and experience, was privileged and transparent. If you do not know what is going on inside your head, who does? It is a sensible idea. Freud proposes that introspection and self-knowledge may not be clear or transparent, but systematically unreliable. He takes the Cartesian cogito, the observing self that founds Western science, and splits it. This splitting of the subject is analogous to the splitting of the atom in early twentieth-century physics. Dividing an apparently integral unit of matter generates new epistemological problems. Freud similarly splits the integral unit of the psyche, the atom of our mental world, into its components, producing previously undiscovered problems of knowledge.

The Cartesian cogito is easy to understand: you look inside yourself and know what is there, what you are doing and how it works. Freud asks: suppose you do not know yourself. This makes introspection radically ambiguous. We certainly have fears, loves, hates, lusts and other emotions. How should we interpret these raw data if we do not know them with certainty? If they are distorted, how do we escape the labyrinth? Freud seeks the deep structure of the human soul, particularly the structure we do not disclose to ourselves. For Descartes, transparent knowledge of one’s own mind leaves the epistemological problem of other minds. It is difficult to climb out of one’s private psychic shell and discover what others feel. Freud changes that problem: the difficulty is to know your own mind. But cracking that code would provide a skeleton key to other

minds. Although he makes the Cartesian problem harder, if it is soluble for the self, it becomes soluble for everyone. If successful, this is a great epistemological breakthrough, an impressive intellectual gambit and another reason for his influence.

He is extremely imaginative in a way not directly expected of linear, logical science. He wants a scheme of translation between the manifest content of experience and its latent content, between surface and deep structure. Dreaming of fighting Mike Tyson provides a surface structure. The latent structure might displace feelings about a boss, politics or another authority, symbolically re-representing something that causes great anxiety. Freud seeks a kind of algorithm for the transformations through which unconscious processes generate the manifest structure of consciousness. From this perspective, the self is a code. Once cracked, it allows communicative behaviour not previously recognized as such to be translated, and familiar communication such as speech to be understood in a new way.

Freud regards speech as communication, but his translation scheme also permits behaviour previously thought meaningless to be read as symbolic. Someone washing their hands fifteen, twenty or thirty times a day is not simply responding to that much physical dirt. This may symbolically represent unconscious activity. Freud reads rather than merely observes behaviour that seemed to communicate nothing. That is the deep and impressive achievement. From this scheme and model of the psyche, he extrapolates to art, culture and other matters, producing a pessimistic social philosophy.

He views religion as a giant anxiety neurosis. The human ego or self is not naturally good in Rousseau’s sense. It is driven by the pleasure principle until the reality principle intervenes. We are born tyrannical machines for absorbing pleasure and become civilized and social through collisions with reality. This is an anti-Rousseauian, pessimistic account of the human condition. Civilization causes discontent, but without it we would be pure monsters of desire. Freud connects self and society. Such extrapolation is at least as old as Plato. The social philosophy is not merely an epiphenomenon or incidental by-product, but an important element of the project.

Freud was a brilliant student, always outstanding at school. His scientific training was shaped by the materialist school of Helmholtz, notably through Brücke, and he attended Franz Brentano’s lectures while studying medicine. Brentano is little read today and often treated as secondary in philosophy’s history, but he was an important teacher of Freud, Edmund Husserl and other influential late nineteenth-century intellectuals. He added to Freud’s rigorous materialism a set of assertions about the mind: the intentional qualities of the psyche cannot simply be eliminated. Guilt, anger, fear, love and lust remain and do not presently reduce to F = ma. Freud nevertheless believes they will ultimately do so, accepting positivistic reduction as a regulative ideal of science. Brentano is closer to an idealist: objective and subjective reality require different vocabularies. Scientists such as Freud tend instead to regard the world as homogeneous in principle, so psychic life ought to be reducible to biochemical events. This seems sensible enough.

Many accept this prospect, but in some respects it remains a bluff. That is why Brentano matters. Perhaps in a thousand centuries science will describe guilt, lust or rage through biochemical events and synaptic firing. For now, however, this is not something we will soon achieve. Meanwhile, we may wish to discuss internal experience: good and evil, love and hate, lust and guilt. Why wait until science actually does the job? This is a sensible observation. Brentano treats it as a special realm of discourse; Freud says that

ultimately it will reduce to physics. After genuflecting before physics, he then discusses the Oedipus complex, lust, rage and guilt in terms not reducible to it. Wanting both creates a rich ambiguity, explaining his work's fruitfulness and its multivocal interpretations. Because the tension is never resolved, different readings remain possible. Ambiguity can sometimes help rather than impede thought.

Freud studies the mind's internal contents as a physician also interested in their physical basis. In further training as a neurological specialist, he studied with Charcot and collaborated with Breuer and other leading investigators. They were particularly interested in hysteria. Women, notably upper-middle-class women in Vienna and affluent Europe, appeared to suffer illnesses without an identifiable organic source: psychosomatic paralysis, hysterical laughter or obscure illnesses confining them to bed. What was this disease apparently lacking a bodily basis? An answer consonant with Brentano's approach was that it might be an illness of the mind. Further evidence suggested the importance of talking to patients. Under hypnosis, some lost their paralysis or other symptoms.

Freud found this peculiar: if the problem was material, why could talking, a non-chemical intervention, produce a physical result? He reached no completely satisfactory conclusion. In 1895, he published *Studies on Hysteria* with Breuer, including Breuer's account of Anna O. Soon afterwards, he developed his seduction theory, presented in 1896. Hysterical symptoms were traced to earlier sexual trauma, often involving someone in the family. Memories of the trauma were repressed and then unconsciously symbolized through symptoms. The unconscious is what bridges the gap between the child and the adult. It is therefore fruitful for a theory of neurosis. He later came to doubt whether all the childhood scenes he reconstructed were historical events.

After reconsidering the material, Freud concluded that some scenes could be fantasies rather than actual events. This revision has generated considerable controversy. Whether individual patients had suffered sexual abuse cannot always be determined from surviving evidence. Some accounts or reconstructions may have been accurate and others not. No single logical procedure establishes which is which. One must do the best one can with the material. This is a characteristic difficulty with Freudianism: it is often more a hermeneutic, a principle of interpretation, than a science. Such principles offer a range of possible interpretations. Freud vacillates about hysteria's origins, then shifts from seduction towards unconscious sexual fantasies and a blockage of sexual energy.

Freud makes use of many hydraulic metaphors. These are metaphors: psychic energy is not energy in the sense that light or electricity is energy. It is metaphorical, mental energy. Many mistaken biological readings of Freud arise from literalizing such metaphors.

In this account, blocked psychic energy and unconscious sexual longings become hysterical symptoms. How is the problem to be solved? The talking cure emerges. Freud and Breuer find that asking patients what is happening in their minds, how they feel and what upsets them can produce catharsis. In some cases, this causes a remission of symptoms. Freud concludes that symptoms symbolically represent unconscious sexual desires. Finding a verbal way to symbolize these desires removes the need to symbolize them as hysteria. These are the beginnings of the cathartic talking cure. His father's death in 1896 opens another major phase.

Freud begins what he calls self-analysis. Introspection ultimately underlies every psychology, even when psychologists prefer not to admit it: their own experience is the starting point. What else could it be founded upon? This raises questions about how one analyses oneself. There are questionable intellectual moves in being the one person to whom the unconscious is transparent. Freud nevertheless analyses himself and develops an account of his own and others' real motives. From here begins his work on dreams, one of his great achievements. *The Interpretation of Dreams* was published in 1899 with the date 1900 on its title page.

Dreams, he argues, are the royal road to the unconscious. They project otherwise censored feelings and express unconscious wishes, with sexual wishes occupying a central place in his interpretation. They are wish fulfilments. Children's dreams can be straightforward: a mountain of sweets appears because the child would like a mountain of sweets. Adult dreams are different. With the development of what Freud later calls the superego, sexual longings produce shame, discomfort or guilt. They are therefore transposed, displaced or symbolically reformulated.

During waking life, mental censorship excludes uncomfortable thoughts, including Oedipal thoughts of killing one's father or having sexual relations with one's mother or siblings. Such wishes would be great transgressions, and the waking mind refuses to acknowledge them. When censorship relaxes during sleep, they can be expressed in dreams, removing pressure from mechanisms of repression that might otherwise become overloaded. There is an economy of the psyche, maintaining a dynamic equilibrium. In waking life, moral demands direct activities while the ego integrates desires. Sleeping life permits something like a bacchanalia of the id: aggressive and sexual desires find an outlet. Excessive repression risks breaking down the defences. Properly analysed dreams reveal symbolic transformations of longings and a release of pressure.

The unconscious provides a kind of algebraic transformation between manifest dream data and the latent data of psychic life. Technical ideas include displacement, transformation, condensation and overdetermination. Dreams express longings economically. Fighting a tiger might symbolize an intellectual problem, one's wife, boss or children. It may symbolize not merely one of these, but several at once. Condensation brings two, three or four psychic states or unacceptable longings into a single symbolic structure. Dreams are overdetermined: they have multiple causes. This is intuitively plausible, but generates epistemological problems. Dreams and hysteria are now connected through their relation to the unconscious.

A third phenomenon joins these apparently unrelated things: parapraxis, the technical term for errors or faulty actions. People make mistakes continually. Freud studies them in the early twentieth century, publishing *The Psychopathology of Everyday Life* in 1901 and *Jokes and Their Relation to the Unconscious* in 1905.

Mistakes become another symbolic representation of unconscious desires. Forgetting a name need not be an arbitrary failure of memory. Freud may read it as dislike of the person whose name is forgotten. One does not want to acknowledge the dislike, so simply claims not to remember. He finds this suspicious. Calling Dr Freud "Dr Fraud" by a slip of the tongue might be interpreted not merely as a mistake of the palate but as a mistake of the psyche: an expression of what the speaker thinks of this intellectual activity. In this reading, slips are Freudian, symbolically representing wishes one does

not know one possesses. This connects parapraxis, dreams and hysteria as manifestations of the unconscious.

Freud reads human behaviour as a language or set of languages, the code through which the unconscious discloses itself. It is a brilliant and deep connection of surprisingly heterogeneous phenomena. Who would have imagined connecting slips of the tongue, dreams and hysteria? The next major development concerns infantile sexuality, among his most controversial ideas. Abandoning Rousseau's optimistic view of human nature, Freud sees human beings as little monsters of desire. Infants want a bottle, to be changed, to be warm, held and cared for, to sleep and to wake. Their demands are incessant. Society does not corrupt them; it civilizes and tames them into social animals. The infant follows the pleasure principle. Freud uses sexuality here in a broad sense.

For most of us, sexuality concerns adult activity, usually requiring puberty. Freud means sexuality in the extended sense of bodily pleasure. An infant's sexual life includes drinking its bottle, longing for the breast and wanting warmth. The distinction matters. Human development proceeds through stages, from the oral to the anal and ultimately the genital phase. The final genital phase represents healthy adult sexuality, a pursuit of pleasure that is natural and socially satisfactory. From infantile sexuality and psychic development, Freud constructs a developed theory of the unconscious, the heart of his system.

The unconscious itself is an old idea, at least as old as Schopenhauer. Freud did not invent it. What is revolutionary and interesting is his claim to explain law-like unconscious activity. It is not arbitrary or chaotic, merely idiosyncratic or subjective. Unconscious activities share a discernible structure. Mistakes refer back to particular unconscious processes. Although one person's dreams differ from another's, each corresponds structurally to that person's unconscious. Explaining these definable regularities is Freud's great achievement as he understands it.

By *The Ego and the Id* in 1923, Freud has developed the familiar three-part model: id, ego and superego. The tripartite form itself is not new. Plato's gold, silver and bronze offer a structural analogy, as does the Christian conception of God, man and the devil. These are symbolic representations of different psychic attitudes. Earlier versions belong to pre-scientific societies; Freud writes in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century German-speaking Europe. In this comparison, he reformulates familiar structures of the soul. Sociality and moral conduct correspond to the superego, God or Plato's gold; sexual and destructive drives correspond to the id, the devil or Plato's bronze. These are structural analogies, not identical doctrines.

Freud also develops his account of defence mechanisms. Confronting the world, the psyche seeks pleasure and the gratification of natural desires, but repeatedly encounters barriers. One cannot have sexual relations with everyone one wants, or all the food and drink in the world. Infinite pleasure is impossible. When the reality principle frustrates desire, defence mechanisms arise. Freud details the transformations through which these mechanisms distort consciousness. He offers a general pattern supposedly true of all psyches and their worldly interactions: an oscillation between pleasure and reality. Towards the end of his life, he extrapolates from the individual and inevitable social frustrations to a pessimistic social and political philosophy.

In *The Future of an Illusion* (1927), Freud argues that the monotheism of Judaism, Christianity and Islam is an infantile neurosis: an inflated desire for a permanent, universal father. God is the father in the sky, supervising and directing everything, omnipotent and omniscient, as wonderful as one's father seemed at the age of one. But children grow older. Their fathers are no longer all-powerful or all-knowing, neither the best nor the only fathers in the world, but ordinary mortals. Religious belief projects unconscious longings for love, moral security and moral order. We follow the pleasure principle, wanting to believe, rather than the reality principle that denies such a being. Freud greatly admires Nietzsche and displays a similarly ruthless drive to dissolve comforting illusions.

Freud is sometimes read as a crude moral hedonist. There is material for that reading, but it is not entirely fair. He is also concerned with the Delphic injunction to know ourselves. He asks us to stop being enslaved by the pleasure principle, confront the reality principle and discover what we really are. We may not want to believe his account, and he names that unwillingness resistance. Resistance is like a bird dog locating a bird the hunter cannot see. The analyst talks until resistance appears; it points towards unconscious longings. Following it brings the hidden feelings into view.

On this interpretation, Freud wants us to know ourselves and regards truth as ultimately more important than pleasure. It is a grim philosophy, neither especially edifying nor comforting. It asks us to stop deceiving ourselves and believing in a father in the sky. Adults should recognize how anxiety about moral order makes us project longings for morality, unity and meaning onto the world. Freud asks that we confront the reality principle rather than merely follow pleasure. This fine thought does him more justice than a reductive hedonistic reading.

After *The Future of an Illusion* comes *Civilization and Its Discontents*. Freud is a master of the short work, and this is one of his great little books. We all desire pleasure, especially sex and aggression, but civilization requires these desires to be systematically frustrated. They cannot be satisfied outside civilization either: Hobbes describes life in the state of nature as nasty, brutish and short. Human existence needs society. Yet society prohibits sexual relations with parents, siblings and children as incest. Freud argues that human beings possess the desires being prohibited; otherwise the prohibition would be unnecessary.

There is no taboo against sprouting wings and flying, because nobody does it. Freud interprets incest prohibitions across cultures as evidence of desires that require restraint. Otherwise, on this account, they would be superfluous. If they reflect intrinsic human tendencies, we are in a double bind. Happiness is unavailable outside civilization and, alas, within it too. The conflict between individual and society cannot ultimately be resolved. This is a deeply pessimistic conception.

There are provisional accommodations. According to Freud, the best possibility is sublimation. A small, gifted portion of society transforms unconscious sexual and aggressive wishes into something creative, beautiful and socially desirable: art, religion and philosophy. On this account, great artists are wounded or distorted psyches compensating for psychic defects by creating beauty, for example on the Sistine Chapel ceiling. There is an argument for this, though it may be reductive. It is not clear that all art sublimates sexual wishes. Even putting that problem aside, most people lack the talent to sublimate their desires in art or philosophy.

Football on Sunday afternoon offers a more ordinary outlet. Aggressive men watch powerful players collide, experience catharsis and return to work without punching the boss on Monday morning. This illustrates channeling aggression into socially useful forms. The difficulty is the residue left over. The transformation is never complete. Unsatisfied, indeed unsatisfiable longings remain. That conflict is the human condition.

The implication is grimly anti-Rousseauian. Rousseau wants fundamentally to change society because a wicked world corrupts us. Freud reverses the argument: we were problematic to begin with, and the world did what it could to make us better than we would otherwise be. Even that result is not very good. This negative emphasis is not an incidental epiphenomenon. His social theory is built into his theory of the individual psyche. An assessment should appreciate as well as criticize Freud: much here is worthwhile.

In this critical reading, biological and positivistic interpretations of Freud as a natural scientist are mistaken. Moving beyond that misunderstanding allows greater appreciation of him. Consider falsifiability. Karl Popper and other critics concerned with scientific method ask how psychoanalytic claims can be tested and potentially falsified. Scientific hypotheses must be open to tests capable of showing them false. Water boils at about 100 degrees Celsius under standard atmospheric pressure. A Bunsen burner, water and a thermometer allow the claim to be tested under specified conditions. For physical facts, there is a procedure for returning to the investigation and checking the answer.

Freud holds on to eventual reduction to biochemical states. Yet how could one establish that an unknown stranger in a particular dream represents the father? There is no corresponding laboratory procedure necessarily settling that interpretation. Scientific critics therefore assign it the status of religion or, more charitably, literary criticism: a way of interpreting the world, without grounds to pound the desk and insist that it is the only one. There is a plurality of possible interpretations. Freudian analysis does not speak with the single voice expected of physics. It offers multiple hermeneutics and perspectives, resisting the scientific certainty or univocality many desire. Does one analyse dreams as one analyses blood? The analysis is different and partly metaphorical.

Blood can be separated into chemical components. A dream cannot be put in a centrifuge and spun around. The analyst instead asks for free association, fishing for a scheme to translate manifest dream content into latent content. When enough has been gathered and the analyst feels able to interpret the dream, the search ends. This is a different kind of analysis from chemical analysis.

Freud describes dreams as products of condensation: many different things are symbolized in one image, such as an alligator trying to eat the dreamer. If condensation and overdetermination are accepted, the image arises from many feelings. How can we know when interpretation has exhausted them? The process is potentially endless. In practice, Freud knew he had finished when he judged the interpretation complete. Different psychologists asking different questions in free association might reach different readings. Overdetermination prevents a certain final end. There is no purely logical way to close the interpretation. This points towards Aristotle’s phronesis.

Aristotle holds that moral judgment requires phronesis, practical judgment or wisdom. No single formula determines right and wrong. General parameters can be established, but particulars resist formulaic treatment. Psychoanalysis may be similar. It requires

good judgment; one would not want an analyst without it. Yet people with good judgment can disagree. This subjective element cannot be eliminated, another reason psychoanalysis resists becoming a strict natural science. Freud grew up and developed in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century German-speaking Europe, where science enjoyed extraordinary epistemological prestige.

Everyone genuflected before science. In this interpretation, Freud metaphorically put on the white laboratory coat to have his treatment of internal psychic facts taken seriously. Preserving that image now is a mistake: many claims fail as natural science. Part of the problem concerns the German word Wissenschaft. Ordinary English “science” usually denotes physics, chemistry, biology or astronomy. Literary criticism and theology are not ordinarily called sciences. German does not divide knowledge in the same way.

Wissenschaft means an organized body of knowledge. It includes physics, chemistry and astronomy, but also Literaturwissenschaft, literary studies, and theology as a scholarly discipline. In that sense, psychoanalysis and Freud’s entire project are scientific: they organize knowledge as literary criticism does. Like criticism or theology, however, they are multivocal. Their system of interpretation does not exclude other systematic interpretations. It is not scientific in the same sense as physics. The unconscious is not an entity in the same sense as the liver.

Avoiding these category mistakes allows appreciation of Freud as a great thinker. The internal contents of the psyche resist strict natural-scientific discussion. Atoms and chemicals are external and publicly examinable, and language itself belongs to the public domain. Speaking about fears, loves, hates, dreams and desires attempts to make something private and internal external. Language has difficulty crossing that boundary. Ambiguity inevitably arises, as do phenomena for which a satisfactory scientific account is difficult to give. Perhaps, as a regulative ideal, science will explain guilt or lust chemically in a thousand centuries. What should we do meanwhile? Freud offers a Wissenschaft of the mind: organized knowledge interpreting previously uninterpreted things and connecting apparently meaningless phenomena, such as handwashing and dreams, through a general conception. Bringing together what seemed impossible to connect is his great achievement.

Another problem concerns the origin of this psychic structure. From a Darwinian perspective, human beings emerge through a long, branching history, from remote simple organisms through mammalian and primate ancestors. Freud does not satisfactorily account for where the psyche in his particular sense comes from. Amoebas presumably have no Oedipus complex; perhaps other great apes do not either, though this is less certain. If it is specifically human, how did it arise? At some point it was absent; now it is present. Sexual and reproductive drives may be ancient instincts. But the transition to this specific psychic organization still needs explanation.

Why do humans create incest prohibitions, and where do they come from? In *Totem and Taboo* (1913), Freud proposes a primal horde dominated by a father. Expelled brothers unite, kill and eat him, then renounce the women they desired. Guilt and the need to live together lead to prohibitions against incest and killing the father’s substitute. This speculative reconstruction has no established empirical basis as a particular historical event. No such original horde, family or single founding incest prohibition has been demonstrated. It may offer a metaphorical explanation, but cannot be treated as established history. It is among Freud’s most poetic and least scientific constructions,

and he can be self-indulgent here. It does not satisfactorily explain the psyche's origin or the development of its structure over evolutionary time.

A satisfactory developmental account would be desirable, though how to construct it remains unclear. The final point is that phronesis cannot be removed from psychoanalytic interpretation of the human psyche. Judgment makes it multivocal rather than univocal, a hermeneutic or set of interpretive principles rather than a natural science. As a way of interpreting human behaviour, it can nevertheless be fruitful and insightful. Calling Freud "Professor Fraud," for instance, might disclose something about the speaker's attitude.

The difficulty is deciding which errors mean something. Someone typing a text makes many mistakes. Are they all parapraxes, messages from the unconscious? Some seem merely accidental, such as "tre" instead of "the." What does that mean? Requiring every error to have meaning seems Procrustean and dogmatic. If only some errors are messages from the unconscious, which ones? Without a single decision procedure, judgment remains necessary. One error is read as a message and another is not. "Sometimes a cigar is just a cigar," as a saying often attributed to Freud puts it, though there is no evidence that he said it.

The result is a relatively indeterminate system longing for the crystalline internal coherence and univocality of physics without achieving them. Freud can be read as one of the greatest poets of the twentieth century. This unusual reading is not meant to denigrate him. Literature and poetry genuinely teach us things. Those insisting that his work must be natural science sometimes assume all knowledge is physics. That is simply wrong. Physics alone will not teach us guilt, good and evil, love and hate.

Such things can be learned poetically, through literature. Freud's work is one of the great literary achievements of the twentieth century, a new kind of lyric poetry. Love and emotion are discussed in a vocabulary shaped by nineteenth-century German scientific philosophy. He tries to force the material of lyric poetry into the form of German positivism, producing an influential system with profound internal contradictions and tensions. His achievement's richness and greatness lie in making these contradictions fruitful rather than sterile: a road inward rather than a dead end.